

HUNTERS AND CHARIOTEERS

The people of Rome had lots of time off work. By the 3rd century CE, they enjoyed 200 public holidays a year! The city's authorities knew that if the people had nothing to do in their spare time, they might get bored and start rioting. As well as gladiatorial games, the state organized other entertainment to try to keep the masses happy—and it worked.

GIRAFFES WERE JUST ONE OF THE EXOTIC ANIMALS BROUGHT TO ROME.

Animals to the slaughter

Gladiators were not the only creatures to die in the arena. Games held at the Colosseum usually combined the killing of men—and sometimes women—with the mass slaughter of animals. The general rule was that animals were slaughtered in the morning, while humans were killed off at lunchtime and in the afternoon.

The Romans had a word for shows that featured animals—*venationes*. Strictly speaking, this

word means “animal hunts,” but the shows weren’t always as savage as it suggests. At some events, animals were paraded before the crowd simply because they were unusual species seldom seen in Rome. Imagine being there when a giraffe went on show. People were amazed that such an odd-looking animal could exist. The Roman name for a giraffe was “spotted camel” (*camelopardalis*).

Other shows were more like present-day circus acts, where dangerous animals performed

